The Fabric Reader

Twenty-one fibres from the sewn-in label: what each is, what it cost the animal where there was one, and what exists instead.

FREE · WITH A POCKET CARD · 10 PAGES

REFERENCE · 21 FIBRES

EDITION 1 · NOVEMBER 2026

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The Fabric Reader

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PART ONE

How to read the label

Three things to know before the fibre names mean anything.

01 Read the percentages, not the swing tag

In most markets the sewn-in label is a required statement of fibre content, by percentage. The card tied to the sleeve is marketing. When the two disagree in emphasis, the sewn-in one is the one that counts.

02 A fibre name is not a welfare claim

The label tells you what a garment is made of. It does not tell you where the fibre was grown or sheared, how an animal was kept, or who sewed it. Those answers, where they exist, sit in a named certification — or nowhere.

03 “Vegan” and “faux” say what it is not

Neither word tells you what the material is. Turn to the fibre list for that, and then to the entry for that fibre here.

PART TWO

Animal fibres

13 materials taken from an animal, with the welfare position on each and what can be worn instead.

Leather

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Tanned hide, mostly a co-product of the beef and dairy industries (cattle), but also goat, sheep, pig, and — in luxury — exotic species.
WELFARE	Tied directly to the meat/dairy system: the same slaughter, plus welfare issues in some sourcing countries. 'Genuine leather' tells you nothing about the animal's life.
INSTEAD	Cactus (Desserto), mycelium/mushroom (Mylo, Reishi), cork, Piñatex (pineapple leaf), apple and grape leather, and recycled/bio-based synthetics. Note some 'vegan leathers' are plastic-based.
SOURCE	FOUR PAWS Leather; Collective Fashion Justice; Higg MSI.

Wool

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Fibre shorn from sheep (merino, lambswool), also goats (mohair, cashmere) and others. Marketed as natural and renewable.
WELFARE	Key issue is mulesing — cutting skin from lambs' hindquarters, still legal in parts of Australia. Shearing can be rushed and rough on a piecework system. Look for non-mulesed / RWS-certified wool.
INSTEAD	Recycled wool, organic non-mulesed wool (RWS), and plant fibres — organic cotton, hemp, linen, TENCEL lyocell, and innovative fibres like nettle.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange RWS; FOUR PAWS; PETA mulesing investigations.

Cashmere

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Ultra-fine undercoat combed or shorn from cashmere goats, largely from Mongolia and China. Very high yield per garment relative to the animal.
WELFARE	Combing can be painful if rushed; goats are vulnerable to cold after harvesting. Rapid demand has driven welfare and herd-size problems.
INSTEAD	Recycled cashmere, ethically-certified cashmere (e.g. SFA, The Good Cashmere Standard), and soft plant/regenerated fibres like TENCEL or organic cotton blends.
SOURCE	Sustainable Fibre Alliance; Textile Exchange.

Down & Feathers

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	The soft under-plumage of ducks and geese, used as insulation in jackets and bedding.
WELFARE	Live-plucking and force-feeding (for foie gras co-product down) are the core concerns. RDS/Downpass certification prohibits both — look for it explicitly.
INSTEAD	Recycled down, and plant/recycled synthetic insulations — PrimaLoft Bio, recycled polyester fill, kapok, and plant-down (e.g. FLWRDWN).
SOURCE	Textile Exchange RDS; FOUR PAWS.

Silk

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Filament unwound from the cocoon of the silkworm (the domesticated moth Bombyx mori).
WELFARE	Conventional silk boils or steams the cocoons with the pupae still inside, killing them, to keep the filament unbroken. 'Peace silk'/Ahimsa silk lets the moth emerge first.
INSTEAD	Peace/Ahimsa silk, and plant/regenerated fibres — TENCEL, cupro, bamboo lyocell, and the lab-grown protein 'spider silk' (e.g. Brewed Protein).
SOURCE	Collective Fashion Justice; Higg MSI.

Fur

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Pelt with the hair still attached, from farmed mink, fox, raccoon dog, chinchilla, or trapped wild animals.
WELFARE	Farmed fur animals are typically kept in small wire cages and killed by gassing or electrocution. Trapping causes prolonged suffering. Fur farming is now banned or being phased out in much of Europe.
INSTEAD	There is no ethical case for new fur. For the look, choose recycled or plant-based faux textures — though check these aren't pure virgin plastic — or simply other materials entirely.
SOURCE	Humane Society International; FOUR PAWS; Fur Free Alliance.

Mohair

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Lustrous fibre from the Angora goat, much of it from South Africa — the world's largest producer.
WELFARE	PETA's 2018 investigation into South African mohair farms prompted many brands to drop it; the industry responded with the Responsible Mohair Standard (RMS). Look for RMS certification.
INSTEAD	RMS-certified mohair, recycled fibres, and soft plant/regenerated alternatives (brushed organic cotton, TENCEL blends).
SOURCE	Textile Exchange RMS; PETA mohair investigation 2018.

Angora

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Extremely soft fibre from the Angora rabbit (distinct from Angora goat mohair).
WELFARE	Undercover footage of live-plucking of rabbits led most major retailers to ban angora. The welfare risk is high and hard to verify.
INSTEAD	Brushed cotton, recycled fibres, and soft synthetics or regenerated cellulosics for the same halo/softness.
SOURCE	PETA angora investigations; retailer bans (2013 onward).

Exotic skins

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Leather from crocodiles, alligators, snakes, lizards, and ostriches, used in luxury bags, shoes, and straps.
WELFARE	Serious welfare concerns in farming and killing methods; some sourcing intersects with wildlife-trafficking and CITES-protected species.
INSTEAD	Embossed plant leathers and textured bio-based materials replicate the look without the animal or the trafficking risk.
SOURCE	CITES; FOUR PAWS; Collective Fashion Justice.

Alpaca

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Fibre shorn from alpacas, marketed as a soft, warm luxury wool alternative from South America (mainly Peru).
WELFARE	Shearing can be rough; a 2020 investigation documented handling that distressed the animals. No universal welfare standard covers most alpaca supply.
INSTEAD	Recycled wool, organic cotton, Tencel/lyocell blends for warmth.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange; PETA alpaca investigation (2020).

Shearling

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	A sheep or lamb skin tanned with the wool still on — hide and fleece in one piece. Not the same as shorn wool.
WELFARE	Requires the animal to be slaughtered for its skin; a slaughter product, not a shearing by-product.
INSTEAD	Faux shearling from recycled polyester, or Tencel-pile fabrics.
SOURCE	Collective Fashion Justice; FOUR PAWS.

Peace Silk (Ahimsa)

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Silk where moths are allowed to emerge from the cocoon before it is processed, marketed as a cruelty-reduced alternative to conventional silk.
WELFARE	Better than conventional silk (which boils the pupae alive), but the moths are still bred, often flightless, and short-lived. ‘Cruelty-free’ claims are contested.
INSTEAD	Tencel, cupro (regenerated cotton linter), or high-quality viscose for drape.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange; peer-reviewed sericulture studies.

Merino wool

ANIMAL-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Fine wool from merino sheep, dominant in activewear and base layers, mostly from Australia and New Zealand.
WELFARE	The key issue is mulesing — cutting skin from the lamb's hindquarters, often without pain relief, to prevent flystrike. Non-mulesed and RWS-certified wool exists.
INSTEAD	Non-mulesed or RWS-certified merino; recycled wool; plant-based performance fibres.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange RWS; FOUR PAWS mulesing reporting.

PART THREE

Plant and synthetic fibres

Not automatically better, and not all alike. What each is, and what to ask of it.

Viscose / Rayon

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	A regenerated cellulosic fibre made by chemically dissolving wood pulp and re-forming it as a filament. Semi-synthetic, not a true natural fibre.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue, but conventional viscose has been linked to deforestation of ancient/endangered forests for pulp.
INSTEAD	Closed-loop lyocell (TENCEL) recycles its solvent and uses certified wood; look for FSC pulp and CanopyStyle-audited suppliers. EcoVero is a lower-impact viscose.
SOURCE	Canopy Hot Button Report; Changing Markets Foundation.

Cotton

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	The classic plant fibre from the cotton plant's seed boll. Breathable, biodegradable, and animal-free.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue; the concerns are human — forced labour has been documented in some cotton supply chains (e.g. certain regions), and pesticide exposure for farmers.
INSTEAD	Organic cotton (GOTS), recycled cotton, and lower-thirst fibres — hemp, linen, and TENCEL — for many of the same uses.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange; Better Cotton Initiative.

Hemp & Linen

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Bast fibres from the hemp and flax plants — among the oldest and lowest-impact textiles. Animal-free.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue.
INSTEAD	These ARE the alternative — reach for them in place of thirstier or animal fibres. Blends with organic cotton or TENCEL soften the feel.
SOURCE	Higg MSI; Textile Exchange.

Recycled Polyester (rPET)

SYNTHETIC / PROCESSED

WHAT IT IS	Polyester spun from recycled plastic (often bottles) rather than virgin fossil feedstock. Common in activewear and fleece.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue.
INSTEAD	Prefer natural fibres for anything washed often; use a microfibre-catching wash bag; and choose rPET over virgin synthetic when a synthetic is genuinely needed.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange; Ellen MacArthur Foundation.

Bamboo fabric

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Usually 'bamboo' clothing is actually bamboo VISCOSE — the plant is dissolved and regenerated like rayon, not woven from the raw plant.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue.
INSTEAD	Bamboo lyocell (closed-loop) over bamboo viscose; or TENCEL, hemp, and organic cotton for a verified lower-impact choice.
SOURCE	US FTC bamboo labelling rulings; Canopy.

Organic cotton

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	Cotton grown without synthetic pesticides or fertilisers, certified by standards such as GOTS or OCS.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue. Labour conditions vary — certification and audits matter, and audits can be gamed.
INSTEAD	Recycled cotton, hemp, linen for lower water impact.
SOURCE	Textile Exchange; GOTS.

Tencel / Lyocell

PLANT-DERIVED

WHAT IT IS	A regenerated cellulose fibre made from wood pulp in a closed-loop solvent process, branded Tencel by Lenzing.
WELFARE	No animal welfare issue.
INSTEAD	Already a strong alternative; look for FSC-certified feedstock.
SOURCE	Canopy; Lenzing published data.

Deadstock / recycled fabric

SYNTHETIC / PROCESSED

WHAT IT IS	Leftover or reclaimed fabric diverted from waste — marketed as circular. 'Deadstock' is loosely defined and sometimes overstated.
WELFARE	Depends on the original fibre; a deadstock wool is still wool.
INSTEAD	Certified recycled content (GRS) with traceability.
SOURCE	Changing Markets Foundation; Textile Exchange GRS.

PART FOUR

The pocket card

The fibre names and the marks, on something small enough to carry.

PRINT AT 100%. CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINE. FOLD ONCE.

FERAL FEMME. WARDROBE · POCKET CARD

Before the till: the label

Read the sewn-in label, by percentage. The swing tag is marketing.

Animal fibres, by name: Leather · Wool · Cashmere · Down & Feathers · Silk · Fur · Mohair · Angora · Exotic skins · Alpaca · Shearling · Peace Silk (Ahimsa) · Merino wool.

"Vegan" and "faux" say what it is not. Find the fibre.

Marks about animals: Leaping Bunny · PETA — Beauty Without Bunnies · Certified Vegan (Vegan Society / Vegan Action) · RSPCA Assured · Certified Humane · Responsible Down / Wool Standard (RDS / RWS) · ZQ Merino. Look each one up.

A fibre name is not a welfare claim. That sits in a named certification, or nowhere.

A PROMPT FOR READING A LABEL · NOT ADVICE · FERAL-FEMME.CO/TOOLS

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CORRECTIONS

If something here is wrong, we would rather hear it than not: info@feral-femme.co. Substantive corrections are published in full at feral-femme.co/corrections/, with what was said, what was wrong, and when it changed.

EDITION

Edition 1 · November 2026. Published by FERAL FEMME, an independent publication. The reference entries are generated from the datasets behind the free tools at feral-femme.co/tools/, as they stood on the edition date.

WHEN YOU WANT TO PUT IT TO WORK · FERAL-FEMME.CO/SHOP

The Brand Audit Workbook	PREMIUM	Audit a brand from the public record, in six modules.
The Claims Desk	PREMIUM	A claims review procedure and working file, for brands.
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